the policy was largely suspended, only to be revived with little public debate in 2014. “If anything, the study found that the demolitions inflame the public and probably generate more attacks,” said Jeff Halper, the founder of the International Committee Against Home Demolitions, a local activist group. “And there hasn’t been another committee convened that said conditions have changed.”

The practice dates back to 1945, before the state of Israel was founded. The British Mandate passed an emergency resolution that gave military commanders latitude to destroy any house from which they suspected a weapon was fired, or whose inhabitants attempted to violate military law. When Israel occupied the West Bank, it applied a bewildering mix of Jordanian, Ottoman, British and Israeli law, including the 1945 regulation. Over the next twenty years, it demolished or sealed some 1,300 homes; in more than half of those cases, the inhabitants had not committed “actions that involve injury or loss of life.”[4] Hundreds of additional homes were destroyed during both the First and Second Intifadas. (The same regulation is used to justify demolitions in East Jerusalem, even though it has been formally annexed to Israel.)

The policy has regularly been condemned by human rights organizations and has placed Israel on the wrong side of international law. Human Rights Watch refers to it as “blatantly unlawful”. The Fourth Geneva Convention prohibits home demolitions except where “rendered absolutely necessary by military operations”, but the Israeli High Court ruled in both 1979 and 1982 that they were an acceptable punishment.

A key justification for the punitive home demolitions is that families, knowing their homes will be destroyed, will opt to turn in their relatives willingly before the family member can carry out an attack. However, the Shani commission found only about twenty cases where that actually happened, out of more than 660 demolitions. And that modest benefit was outweighed, it concluded, by the anger created amongst Palestinians, and the damage to Israel’s diplomatic reputation. Ironically, it was none other than Defense Minister Moshe Ya’alon who appointed the commission in 2004 during his stint as army chief.

Six weeks before Shalloudi’s house was blown up, on the other side of the ravine, a group of Jewish families moved into seven buildings in the dead of night. The homes were purchased by a pro-settler group called the City of David Foundation, commonly known by its Hebrew acronym Elad.